HARNESS ENGINEERING

"Completed" does not mean the work passed

What to check before a multi-agent run counts as done

8 SLIDES - SAVE FOR YOUR NEXT AGENT HARNESS REVIEW

“The result doesn't say whether the work passed.”

Anthropic docs, Claude Managed Agents: workflow runs

WHAT SHIPPED (BETA, OCT 9)

The agent writes a program that runs the sub-agents

01 **64** threads at once per run

02 **1,000** agents max per run

03 **24h** default run timeout

04 **10** open runs per session

Two ways to call a run done

NAIVE

run.status == completed

Waits for the run to end

Failed threads pass silently

Parent agent builds on bad output

STRICT

all(thread passed check)

Checks every thread result

Any failure blocks the phase

Parent agent sees what broke

WHY IT MATTERS

A quiet "completed" is worse than a crash

A crash stops the parent agent.

A completed run with failed threads lets it move on without knowing.

THE CONTRACT

Map every status code to a rule

01 **program_error** fix the program, do not blind-retry

02 **thread_limit_error** reduce fan-out or split phases

03 **timeout_error** cap scope, then retry once

The done contract

01 Done = every thread passed your check

02 Each status code has a retry rule

03 Capture thread output before it is archived

How does your harness decide a multi-agent run succeeded?

Analysis of Anthropic's docs. No independent test or success-rate data published yet.

Save this for your next harness review